Meeting with Instructors

At some point in our postsecondary education, we may need to meet with the instructor or teaching assistant (TA) - to request an extension to an assignment, ask for clarification about assignment expectations, advocate for accommodations, or challenge a grade

It might seem scary but here are some tips for having a successful meeting.

See the handout on "Managing a bad grade"

1

Make an appointment and prepare for the meeting.

See the handout "Office Hours 101"

2 Who do you talk to?

In large schools and courses, odds are the **teaching assistant (TA)** is grading the work and not the **instructor**.
Make sure you are meeting with the right person.

3 Make a good first impression.

- Be on time to the appointment
- Shake hands and make eye contact (if possible) with the instructor at the beginning of the meeting.
- Identify the reason for the visit.
- Let the instructor know if you have more than one question.

4 Seek to understand.

During the conversation:

Write down the response from the instructor.

Repeat back or summarize their responses to ensure understanding.

Things to say in response to the instructor's answers to your questions:

I need a couple of minutes to think about this. I hope that is okay.

Thank you for answering my question. I'm just going to repeat it back to make sure I understand.

What do you by that example? Is it okay to expand more of provide another example? That would really help me with my learning.

Asking for clarification and reflection

Reflect on what the instructor said. Does it make sense? Have they answered your question?

Repeat or summarize back to the instructor to make sure you understand the response to your question.

It is okay to let the instructor know that you need a few minutes to write down their response or think about it.

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You may want to meet with an instructor or TA to discuss a grade or assignment. Consider these tips for before, during, and after the meeting.

Before the meeting

- Review the instructor's grading rubric. Are there areas you could improve?
- Review the feedback. What needs clarification?
- Identify if there are factors that contributed to the poor grade. e.g., understanding the material, study habits, anxiety, or lack of sleep
- Identify places where you can ask for help or support, e.g., meet with the teaching assistant, writing center.

During the meeting:

- Approach your conversation with an open mind and avoid being defensive.
- Ask what you can do better next time.
- Accept your instructor's advice and move forward.
- Remember to stay courteous and professional, and don't expect special treatment.

At the end of the meeting, thank them for their time

If relevant, follow up with an email thanking them for their time again and outlining what was discussed and concluded at the meeting

"Thank you for meeting with me on [date]. I appreciate your willingness to give me a short extension for [assignment]. As we discussed, I will submit the assignment by [date].

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